Confidence scores

Finding confidently held errors

Use confidence scores alongside answers to identify uncertainty and confidently held errors. Confidence adds context to performance; it does not replace evidence of knowledge.

How to do it well

1 Choose the use. Apply ratings to selected quiz or assessment answers where the information can guide feedback.

2 Explain the scale. Use clear endpoints and establish that honest uncertainty is helpful.

3 Attempt and rate. Students answer independently and record confidence before solutions or discussion.

4 Compare with accuracy. Identify confident errors, uncertain correct answers and insecure knowledge, then probe where needed.

5 Plan the response. Give relevant feedback and future practice, using high-confidence errors for Review Cards where appropriate.

What this sounds like

“Before we reveal the solution, rate how confident you are that your answer is correct. We will compare confidence with the evidence and choose what to revisit.”

Classroom example. A quiz answer is wrong despite a high confidence rating. The teacher uses that mismatch to prioritise the explanation and a Review Card. A correct but uncertain answer receives a reasoning check and further practice. Ratings provide useful context to observed performance, rather than a separate attainment measure.

Top tips that make the technique work

Commit before feedback. Ratings made after seeing the answer cannot reveal the original certainty.

Use a simple scale consistently. For example, explain what the ends of a 0–10 scale mean without turning every number into a complex rubric.

Prioritise confident errors. They are useful candidates for explanation, comparison and Review Cards.

Investigate low-confidence correct answers. The student may need fluency practice or may have guessed.

Keep the tone neutral. Honest uncertainty is more useful than students inflating ratings to appear successful.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Record a rating beside an independent answer.	Treating confidence as attainment.
Use the mismatch to guide review.	Rating only after the correct answer is public.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton — The role of confidence in learning